胡同里的修表师傅

表停了，总得有人修

The Watch Repairer of the Hutong

When a watch stops, someone has to mend it

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Footnotes mark names, festival terms and words above HSK 5 (HSK 3.0 lists: github.com/ivankra/hsk30, MIT).

1 北京的老城里有很多胡同[†]。胡同就是一条条很小的路，路两边是灰色的墙和一个个院子。随着城市的发展，很多胡同已经消失了，可是还有不少留了下来。其中一条叫槐树胡同[‡]，胡同里有一家很小的修表店。店里只有一个人，大家都叫他周师傅。

一个角落[§]

2 周师傅的店在胡同的一个角落里，小得只放得下一张桌子和两把椅子。门口挂着一块木牌子，上面写着四个字："周记修表[¶]"。字是他父亲写的，现在已经有点儿看不清了。桌子已经很旧了，上面放着一个小灯；墙上挂着十几个钟，每个钟的时间都一样。周师傅在这里修表，已经修了四十年。

† 胡同 *hútòng* hutong, old Beijing lane

‡ 槐树胡同 *Huáishù Hútòng* Locust Tree Hutong (fictional)

§ 角落 *jiǎoluò* corner

¶ 周记修表 *Zhōujì Xiūbiǎo* Zhou's Watch Repairs (shop sign)

Beijing's old city is full of hutongs. A hutong is simply a narrow lane, lined on both sides by grey walls and one courtyard after another. As the city has grown, many hutongs have disappeared, but quite a few remain. One of them is called Locust Tree Hutong, and in it there is a very small watch repair shop. Only one man works there, and everyone calls him Master Zhou. 1

A Corner

Master Zhou's shop sits in a corner of the hutong, so small that it holds only a table and two chairs. Over the door hangs a wooden sign with four characters on it: "Zhou's Watch Repairs". His father wrote them, and by now they are hard to make out. The table is very old, with a small lamp on it, and a dozen or so clocks hang on the wall, every one of them showing the same time. Master Zhou has been repairing watches here for forty years. 2

3 每天早上七点，周师傅准时开门。他先把桌子收拾干净，再把工具一件一件地摆好：小螺丝刀[†]、镊子[‡]、放大镜[§]，还有一个装零件[¶]的小盒子。然后他戴上放大镜，低下头，一坐就是一整天。他做事特别有耐心，一个小零件，他可以看上半个小时。胡同[*]里的邻居都说，周师傅的店比钟还准。

4 周师傅的孙女小雨[#]今年二十四岁，在一所大学读产品设计的研究生。她一向喜欢新东西：新手机、新电脑、新的设计软件。在她看来，爷爷的店就像博物馆里的东西，又老又旧，跟现代生活没什么关系。“爷爷，现在谁还戴手表呀？”她常常抱怨，“大家看时间都用手机。您这个店，早就该关了。”周师傅听了，也不生气，只是笑一笑。他一向话不多，只说一句：“表停了，总得有人修。”

† 螺丝刀 *luósīdāo* screwdriver
‡ 镊子 *nièzi* tweezers
§ 放大镜 *fàngdàjìng* magnifying glass, loupe
¶ 零件 *língjiàn* (machine) part
* 胡同 *hútòng* hutong, old Beijing lane
\# 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu

Every morning at seven, Master Zhou opens up, right on time. First he tidies the table, then lays out his tools one by one: a small screwdriver, tweezers, a loupe, and a little box for parts. Then he puts on his loupe, lowers his head, and sits there for the whole day. He is extraordinarily patient: he can look at one tiny part for half an hour. The neighbours in the hutong say Master Zhou's shop keeps better time than a clock. 3

Master Zhou's granddaughter Xiaoyu is twenty-four and studying for a master's degree in product design. She has always loved new things: new phones, new computers, new design software. To her, Grandpa's shop is like something in a museum: old and worn, with nothing to do with modern life. "Grandpa, who still wears a watch these days?" she often complains. "Everyone checks the time on their phone. You should have closed this shop long ago." Master Zhou doesn't get angry when he hears this; he just smiles. He has never been a man of many words. All he says is: "When a watch stops, someone has to mend it." 4

停了的表

5 其实，小雨[†]说得也有道理。随着手机的出现，来修表的人越来越少了。三十年前，店门口常常排着队；现在，有时候一整天也没有一个顾客。周师傅的收入不高，还好店是自己家的，不用交房租。

6 十月的一个下午，小雨来给爷爷送饭。店里来了一位六十多岁的阿姨，手里拿着一个布包。她小心地把布包打开，里面是一块旧手表。“师傅，这块表停了好几年了，”阿姨说，“我去了好几家商场，人家都说没有零件[‡]，修不了。”

7 周师傅接过表，看了一眼，说：“上海牌[§]的，七十年代的吧？”阿姨点点头：“是我父亲结婚的时候买的。那时候大家结婚，都想要‘三转一响[¶]’——自行车、缝纫机[*]、手表和收音机。

† 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu
‡ 零件 *língjiàn* (machine) part
§ 上海牌 *Shànghǎipái* Shanghai brand (watch)
¶ 三转一响 *sān zhuàn yī xiǎng* three that turn, one that rings (wedding goods)
* 缝纫机 *féngrènjī* sewing machine

The Stopped Watch

In fact, Xiaoyu had a point. Since mobile phones came along, fewer and fewer people came to have watches repaired. Thirty years ago there was often a queue outside; now, some days, not a single customer came in. Master Zhou did not earn much; luckily the shop belonged to the family, so he paid no rent. 5

One afternoon in October, Xiaoyu came to bring her grandfather his lunch. A woman in her sixties came into the shop, holding a cloth bundle. She carefully unwrapped it; inside was an old wristwatch. "Master, this watch stopped years ago," she said. "I've tried several department stores, and they all say there are no parts and it can't be fixed." 6

Master Zhou took the watch, glanced at it and said, "A Shanghai, from the seventies, isn't it?" She nodded. "My father bought it when he got married. Back then everyone who got married wanted the 'three things that turn and one that rings': a bicycle, a sewing machine, a watch and a radio. 7

7 这块表是我父亲存了一年多的钱才买到的。据说那时候一块表要一百多块钱，他一个月的工资才三四十块。”

8 阿姨的声音低了下来：“他去年走了。我就想让这块表再走起来。”周师傅打开表的后盖，用放大镜†看了很久。“里面有一个小零件‡坏了，现在买不到。”阿姨的脸一下子暗了。周师傅却接着说：“不过，我可以自己做一个。您一个星期以后来拿吧。”

9 小雨§在旁边听得很奇怪。“爷爷，您要自己做零件？这得花多少时间啊？您收多少钱？”

“五十。”小雨差点儿笑出来：“五十块？连材料费都不够吧！”周师傅慢慢地说：“人家是来修记忆的，不是来让我挣钱的。而且，我毕竟修了四十年表，这点儿事不算难。”

† 放大镜 *fàngdàjìng* magnifying glass, loupe

‡ 零件 *língjiàn* (machine) part

§ 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu

My father saved for more than a year before he could buy this watch. They say a watch cost over a hundred yuan back then, and he earned only thirty or forty a month." 7

Her voice dropped. "He passed away last year. I just want this watch to run again." Master Zhou opened the back of the watch and studied it through his loupe for a long time. "There's a small part broken inside. You can't buy it any more." The woman's face fell at once. But Master Zhou went on, "I can make one myself, though. Come back for it in a week." 8

Xiaoyu, listening nearby, found this very strange. "Grandpa, you're going to make the part yourself? How long will that take? How much are you charging?" "Fifty." Xiaoyu nearly laughed out loud. "Fifty yuan? That won't even cover the materials!" Master Zhou said slowly, "She came to have a memory mended, not to make me money. Besides, I have been repairing watches for forty years, after all. This sort of thing isn't hard." 9

10 一个星期以后，阿姨来了。周师傅把表放在她手里。阿姨把表放到耳边，听见了“滴答[†]、滴答”的声音。她竟然像孩子一样哭了起来，又笑着说：“跟我小时候听到的一模一样[‡]。还是那个熟悉的声音。”小雨[§]站在门口，第一次觉得，爷爷的手好像有一种她不懂的力量。

拆还是不拆

11 十一月，胡同[¶]里贴出了一张通知：槐树胡同[*]要进行改造。通知上说，要修理老房子，改善居民的生活条件，院子外面后来加盖的小房子都要拆掉。周师傅的小店，正是三十多年前在院墙边上加盖的。一开始，很多人以为整条胡同都要拆迁[#]，后来才知道，老院子不拆，还要保护起来。

† 滴答 *dīdā* tick-tock
‡ 一模一样 *yīmú yīyàng* exactly the same
§ 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu
¶ 胡同 *hútòng* hutong, old Beijing lane
* 槐树胡同 *Huáishù Hútòng* Locust Tree Hutong (fictional)
拆迁 *chāiqiān* to demolish and relocate

A week later the woman came back. Master Zhou placed the watch in her hand. She held it to her ear and heard it go "tick-tock, tick-tock". To everyone's surprise she began to cry like a child, then said through a smile, "It sounds exactly the way it did when I was little. That same familiar sound." Standing in the doorway, Xiaoyu felt for the first time that her grandfather's hands held a kind of power she did not understand. 10

To Pull Down or Not

In November a notice went up in the hutong: Locust Tree Hutong was to be renovated. The notice said the old houses would be repaired and the residents' living conditions improved, and that all the small rooms built on later outside the courtyards would be pulled down. Master Zhou's little shop was exactly that: a room built against a courtyard wall more than thirty years ago. At first many people thought the whole hutong would be demolished and everyone moved out; only later did they learn that the old courtyards would not be pulled down but protected. 11

12 消息很快传遍了整条胡同[†]，邻居们都来店里说话。卖早点的王阿姨说：“周师傅，您一向对我们这么好，谁家的钟坏了，您都给修。您这店要是没了，以后我们找谁去？”也有人说：“拆了也好，搬到高楼里去，有暖气，有电梯，多舒服！”

13 小雨[‡]的爸爸也来劝他：“爸，您都七十多了，毕竟年纪大了，眼睛也不如以前了。借这个机会，就别干了，跟我们一起住吧。”周师傅没有说话。他知道儿子是为他好，可是他舍不得这个小店。那天晚上，他一个人悄悄地在店里坐了很久，把墙上的钟一个一个地上好了发条[§]。

14 小雨本来觉得，店关了是一件好事，爷爷终于可以休息了。可是看到爷爷一个人坐在灯下的样子，她心里却有点儿难受。她想起了那位阿姨的眼泪，想起了那个“滴答[¶]”声。

† 胡同 *hútòng* hutong, old Beijing lane
‡ 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu
§ 发条 *fātiáo* mainspring
¶ 滴答 *dīdā* tick-tock

The news spread quickly through the whole hutong, and the neighbours all came by the shop to talk. Auntie Wang, who sold breakfast, said, "Master Zhou, you've always been so good to us. Whenever anyone's clock broke, you fixed it. If your shop goes, who will we turn to?" Others said, "Pulling it down isn't so bad. Move into a high-rise, with heating and a lift. How comfortable!" 12

Xiaoyu's father came to talk him round too. "Dad, you're over seventy. You're getting on, after all, and your eyes aren't what they were. Take this chance to stop working and come and live with us." Master Zhou said nothing. He knew his son meant well, but he could not bear to give up the little shop. That night he sat quietly alone in the shop for a long time, winding the clocks on the wall one by one. 13

Xiaoyu had thought closing the shop would be a good thing: Grandpa could finally rest. But seeing him sitting alone under the lamp, she felt a pang. She remembered the woman's tears, and that "tick-tock". 14

14 她忽然想：如果这家店真的没了，这些东西会不会也一起消失呢？正好，她这个学期有一门课，叫“设计和记忆”。老师要求每个学生拍一个视频，记录一种正在消失的东西。小雨†决定，就拍摄爷爷。

镜头里的手

15 周师傅一开始不同意：“拍我干什么？我一个修表的，有什么好拍的？”小雨说：“就拍您的手，不拍脸，行不行？就当是帮我完成作业。”周师傅犹豫了半天，又仔细问了一遍：“真的不拍脸？”小雨点了点头，他这才答应了。

16 小雨把手机放在桌子上，镜头对着爷爷的手。那是一双很普通的老人的手，又干又瘦，手指却非常稳。

† 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu

Suddenly she wondered: if the shop really disappeared, would all of that disappear with it? As it happened, she had a course that semester called "Design and Memory". The teacher asked every student to make a video recording something that is disappearing. Xiaoyu decided she would film her grandfather. 14

Hands on Camera

At first Master Zhou refused. "Why film me? I'm just a watch repairer. What's there to film?" Xiaoyu said, "Just your hands, not your face. All right? Think of it as helping me with my homework." Master Zhou hesitated for a long time, then asked again, carefully, "You really won't film my face?" Only when Xiaoyu nodded did he agree. 15

Xiaoyu set her phone on the table with the lens pointing at her grandfather's hands. They were very ordinary old man's hands, dry and thin, but the fingers were perfectly steady. 16

16 他用镊子[†]夹起一个比米还小的零件[‡]，轻轻地放进表里，没有一点儿犹豫，一下子就放到了正确的位置。小雨[§]在镜头后面看着，居然紧张得连话都不敢说。

17 她拍摄了整整三个星期。她这才知道，修一块表，要先把它完全拆开。一块普通的老手表里有几十个到一百多个零件，每一个都要洗干净、仔细检查，坏了的要换，有时候还得自己做。然后再一个一个地装回去，最后还要调时间，一天快几秒、慢几秒都要调好。爷爷做这些事的时候，总是很安静，好像整个世界只剩下他和手里的表。

18 有一天，小雨问他："爷爷，您每天做同样的事，不觉得无聊吗？"周师傅想了想，说："每一块表都不一样。有的是结婚时买的，有的是孩子考上大学时父母送的，有的是一个人留给家里的最后一件东西。

† 镊子 *nièzi* tweezers
‡ 零件 *língjiàn* (machine) part
§ 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu

With the tweezers he picked up a part smaller than a grain of rice and set it gently into the watch, placing it exactly right without the slightest hesitation. Watching from behind the camera, Xiaoyu was surprised to find herself so tense she didn't dare say a word. 16

She filmed for three whole weeks. Only then did she learn that to repair a watch, you first have to take it completely apart. An ordinary old watch has anywhere from several dozen to over a hundred parts, and every one must be cleaned and carefully checked; broken ones must be replaced, and sometimes he has to make them himself. Then they go back in one by one, and finally the timing has to be adjusted, until even a few seconds fast or slow a day is put right. When Grandpa did this work he was always quiet, as if the whole world held nothing but him and the watch in his hands. 17

One day Xiaoyu asked him, "Grandpa, you do the same thing every day. Don't you get bored?" Master Zhou thought for a moment. "Every watch is different. Some were bought for a wedding, some were given by parents when a child got into university, and some are the last thing a person left to their family. 18

表停了，好像那段时间也停了。我把它修好，那段时间就又走起来了。”

小雨[†]听了，很久没说话。作为一个学设计的人，她一向相信，好的设计应该让东西更快、更方便。可是爷爷的工作，一点儿也不快，也不算方便，却让人觉得特别温暖。她在视频的最后打了一行字：“有些东西，修好了，就不只是一块表。”

意想不到[‡]

小雨把视频交给了老师，同时也发到了网上。她没想到，第二天早上起床，手机里居然有几百条消息。这个只有五分钟的视频，一夜之间[§]被播放了一百多万次。

† 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu

‡ 意想不到 *yìxiǎng bùdào* unexpected

§ 一夜之间 *yīyè zhījiān* overnight

When a watch stops, it's as if that stretch of time has stopped too. When I mend it, that time starts moving again." 18

Xiaoyu said nothing for a long while. As a design student, she had always believed that good design should make things faster and more convenient. Yet Grandpa's work was not fast at all, nor especially convenient, and still it left you feeling especially warm. At the end of the video she typed one line: "Some things, once mended, are more than just a watch." 19

The Unexpected

Xiaoyu handed the video in to her teacher, and at the same time posted it online. She never expected to wake up the next morning to several hundred messages on her phone. Overnight, the five-minute video had been played more than a million times. 20

21 评论里，很多人写下了自己的故事。有人说：“我爷爷也有一块这样的表，放在柜子里，已经停了二十年。”有人说：“现在什么东西坏了都是扔掉，换新的。没想到竟然还有人这样一点一点地修。太难得了。”还有人问：“这家店在哪儿？我想带我妈妈的表去。”另外一条评论写着：“上个月搬家，我差点儿把奶奶的表扔了。还好没扔。”

22 随着视频越传越广，槐树胡同†一下子热闹了起来。周末，小店门口居然排起了长队，来的大多数是年轻人。他们手里拿着父母的、爷爷奶奶的旧手表，有的连表带都断了。一个男孩说：“这是我爸年轻时戴的。我小时候，他常常把我抱在腿上，让我听表的声音。”

23 周师傅一向不喜欢热闹，一开始有点儿不知道该怎么办。

† 槐树胡同 *Huáishù Hútòng* Locust Tree Hutong (fictional)

In the comments, many people wrote their own stories. One wrote, "My grandpa has a watch just like that, sitting in a cupboard. It stopped twenty years ago." Another wrote, "These days when anything breaks we throw it away and buy a new one. I'd never have thought there was still someone mending things bit by bit like this. That's so rare." Someone else asked, "Where is this shop? I want to take my mum's watch there." Another comment read: "When I moved house last month, I nearly threw my grandma's watch away. Thank goodness I didn't." 21

As the video spread further and further, Locust Tree Hutong suddenly came alive. At the weekend, to everyone's amazement, a long queue formed outside the little shop, and most of the people in it were young. They held their parents' and grandparents' old watches; on some, even the strap had broken. A young man said, "My dad wore this when he was young. When I was little he used to sit me on his knee and let me listen to it ticking." 22

Master Zhou had never liked crowds, and at first he hardly knew what to do. 23

23 可是他修表还是跟以前一样：不着急，一块一块来。奇怪的是，排了很久的人也很少抱怨。有人想多给钱，让他先修自己的，他摇摇头说：“排队吧。表不急，人也别急。”也有人劝他把价钱提高一点儿，多挣点儿钱，他还是只收原来的价钱。

24 有记者来采访，问他对“网红”[†]这个词怎么看。周师傅笑了：“我哪儿是什么网红，我就是个修表的。大家喜欢的，毕竟不是我，是他们自己的记忆。”记者又问：“修了四十年表，您觉得最重要的是什么？”周师傅只说了两个字：“耐心。”

25 这个视频也被街道的工作人员看到了。他们来到店里，跟周师傅商量：胡同[‡]里有一个老院子，正在按照老照片恢复原来的样子，以后要做成一个社区活动的地方。院子里有一间小房子，可以租给周师傅，房租很低。

† 网红 *wǎnghóng* internet celebrity

‡ 胡同 *hútòng* hutong, old Beijing lane

But he repaired watches just as before: no hurry, one at a time. Strangely, even people who had waited a long time rarely complained. When someone offered to pay extra to have theirs done first, he shook his head. "Wait your turn. The watch isn't in a hurry, so don't you be either." Some urged him to raise his prices and earn a bit more, but he still charged what he always had. 23

A reporter came to interview him and asked what he thought of the word "internet celebrity". Master Zhou laughed. "I'm no internet celebrity. I just repair watches. What people love, after all, isn't me. It's their own memories." The reporter asked again, "After forty years of repairing watches, what do you think matters most?" Master Zhou answered in a single word: "Patience." 24

The video was seen by the staff of the local subdistrict office too. They came to the shop to talk things over with Master Zhou: an old courtyard in the hutong was being restored to its original look from old photographs, and would later become a place for community activities. There was a small room in the courtyard that he could rent, at a very low price. 25

25 “像您这样的老手艺†，应该在胡同‡里留下来。”

26 周师傅还没说话，小雨§就先高兴得跳了起来。她发现，自己已经不再觉得这家店是博物馆里的旧东西了。“爷爷，”她说，“新店让我来设计吧！我学了这么多年设计，终于能为您做点儿事了。”

新的院子

27 第二年春天，胡同的改造完成了。灰色的墙重新修过，路也变得平整干净了，老院子也恢复了原来的样子。胡同好像变了，又好像没变。周师傅的新店在那个老院子的东边，比原来的店还要小一点儿。

28 新店是小雨设计的。

† 手艺 *shǒuyì* craft, skill

‡ 胡同 *hútòng* hutong, old Beijing lane

§ 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu

"An old craft like yours ought to stay in the hutong." 25

Before Master Zhou could say anything, Xiaoyu jumped up in delight. She realised she no longer thought of the shop as an old thing from a museum. "Grandpa," she said, "let me design the new shop! After all these years studying design, at last I can do something for you." 26

The New Courtyard

The following spring, the renovation of the hutong was finished. The grey walls had been repaired and the lane was smooth and clean, and the old courtyard had got back its original look. The hutong seemed to have changed, and yet seemed not to have changed at all. Master Zhou's new shop was on the east side of the old courtyard, even a little smaller than the old one. 27

The new shop was Xiaoyu's design. 28

28 她先用设计软件画了十几张图，又一张一张地拿给爷爷看。她把桌子放在窗户前面，窗户做得又大又亮，从外面走过的人，一眼就能看见爷爷工作的手。墙上还是挂着那些旧钟，门口还是那块熟悉的“周记修表”[†]木牌子。店虽然小了，可是她觉得没关系，毕竟爷爷需要的不是大，而是安静。她说：“新店不一定什么都是新的。有些东西，留下来才有意义。”

29 现在，来修表的人比以前多多了。有的人修完了表，还不愿意走，坐在院子里看爷爷工作。社区里的老人也常来坐一坐，王阿姨有时候还给大家带来早点。周末，周师傅还在院子里教几个年轻人修表，他们中间有大学生，也有在公司上班的人。他们说，在这么大的城市里，能安安静静地做一件事，很难得。周师傅说：“我教不了你们什么大道理，就教你们一件事：别着急。”

† 周记修表 *Zhōujì Xiūbiǎo* Zhou's Watch Repairs (shop sign)

She first drew a dozen or so plans with her design software, then showed them to Grandpa one by one. She put the table in front of the window and made the window big and bright, so that anyone walking past could see her grandfather's working hands at a glance. The old clocks still hung on the wall, and the familiar wooden "Zhou's Watch Repairs" sign still hung by the door. The shop was smaller now, but she felt that didn't matter. After all, what Grandpa needed wasn't space but quiet. She said, "A new shop doesn't have to be new in every way. Some things only mean something if you keep them." 28

These days, far more people come to have watches repaired than before. Some, even after their watch is done, don't want to leave, and sit in the courtyard watching Grandpa work. The old folk of the neighbourhood often drop by too, and Auntie Wang sometimes brings breakfast for everyone. At weekends Master Zhou also teaches a few young people to repair watches in the courtyard; among them are university students and office workers. They say that in a city this big, being able to do one thing in peace and quiet is rare. Master Zhou says, "I can't teach you any grand principles. I'll teach you just one thing: don't rush." 29

30 有一天，天快黑的时候，小雨†来接爷爷回家，悄悄地站在门口。最后一点儿阳光照在院子里，墙上的钟一起响了起来。她看着爷爷把工具和零件‡盒子一件一件地收拾好，忽然想起去年自己说过的话：“这个店早就该关了。”她不好意思地笑了。

31 “爷爷，”她说，“我以前觉得，您做的事早就过时§了。现在我才明白，随着时代的变化，很多东西都会改变，可是人总有一些东西舍不得扔掉。”周师傅关上灯，慢慢地说：“表是会停的，人也会老。可是只要有人愿意修，时间就不会真的停下来。”

† 小雨 *Xiǎoyǔ* Xiaoyu

‡ 零件 *língjiàn* (machine) part

§ 过时 *guòshí* outdated

One day, as it was getting dark, Xiaoyu came to take her grandfather home 30
and stood quietly in the doorway. The last of the sunlight fell across the courtyard, and the clocks on the wall all began to chime together. Watching him put away his tools and parts boxes one by one, she suddenly remembered what she had said the year before: "You should have closed this shop long ago." She smiled, a little embarrassed.

"Grandpa," she said, "I used to think your work had gone out of date long 31
ago. Only now do I understand: as the times change, a lot of things change with them, but there are always some things people can't bear to throw away." Master Zhou switched off the lamp and said slowly, "Watches stop, and people grow old. But as long as someone is willing to mend them, time never really stops."